

Final report

I particularly enjoyed several of the seminars this semester, because some of the lecturers did not just deliver a session filled with technical explanations but also imparted a kind of familiar feeling by describing their own personal experiences that led them to where they are today, or personal insight on why they chose to continue their current career path.

For example, Prof. Jr-Ping Wang described a lot of personal experiences and feelings when he talked about how he ended up at Oxford, and I found it actually quite interesting to know the course of events in his life that led him to come across certain opportunities or make those decisions. For example, he talked about how he studied at NTU because he was from Pingtung and wanted to go somewhere far away, and about how his supervisors at NTU and Oxford dealt with him. He said that neither of his supervisors explicitly guided him in his research, but mentioned that it was important for the advisor to inspire students to think about the problem, which I agree with. I was also curious about his perceived cultural differences he said about the UK since I have never been there. I interpreted his statement about how the people “believe everything you say even if it’s ridiculous” as that perhaps people there are more likely to take each other with 100% honesty.

The lecture by Wen-Hsiao Peng on MPEG opened my eyes in an unexpected way about how research in the video industry operated. Namely, that the public standardization (MPEG) way of doing things is rather different from making individual progresses in a privatized manner. I liked learning about this kind of thing even though it’s not about the research detail itself, because it is more like meta-knowledge about the research ecosystem in a particular field. It was useful to hear him discuss the pros and cons of being part of the standardization community rather than the other “camp”, and made me think about similar dynamics that may exist in fields I’m more involved in, that I haven’t thought about before. I learned about how the standardization community tries to generate and decide on new standards in order to adapt to current technology, such as the VVC format to accommodate 360 video and VR.

Lastly, I still want to mention that the gender and science/technology lecture by Wen-Ling Hong was also one that really drew my attention. I have heard this kind of discussion many times in the US, but I liked to hear about how people in different countries approach this problem. Some more valuable information I got from this talk would be examples of these issues being addressed in non-US countries, which is where I was the most exposed gender/science-issue rhetoric. For example, the Frauen-Werk-Stadt project in Germany seemed like a huge success and I feel that the US and maybe other countries can do a better job of addressing this issue by looking more closely at and learning from success stories internationally.